

Episode 33: Special Episode – *The File of Young Kindaichi SP* Broadcast Commemoration – How to Make Hajime-chan's Colours

It's been a while (sweat).

I took two weeks off from the series due to busyness from "*The File of Young Kindaichi*" and other work rushes, then last week I caught a terrible cold and was half-dead. Oh man... (sweat).

Actually, I caught this cold at an exorcism for "*Hakaba Kitaro* (墓場鬼太郎)". It's being called the "Hakaba cold" in some circles (cries). Plus it spread to several *Kindaichi* finishing staff around me, so it's being called the "Kindaichi cold" in some circles (cries).

Anyway, this cold entering its third week, but thankfully I can see the end approaching. Ah, when things settle down I want to go to a hot spring...

When will things settle down? How many days? For better or worse, I'm packed with work until April next year (wails).

Well then.

"*The File of Young Kindaichi*" returned after about 7 years. We made two new titles: "Opera House: The Last Murder" and "Vampire Legend Murder Case." Broadcast over two weeks this week and next. First, "Opera House: The Last Murder" aired on the 12th. Did everyone watch it?

"Opera House: The Last Murder": Script by Shimada Mitsuru (島田満), Character Design & Animation Direction by Takeda Yoshihiro (竹田欣弘), Art Direction by Akiyama Kentaro (秋山健太郎), Direction by Ito Naoyuki (伊藤尚往).

"Vampire Legend Murder Case": Script by Shimada Mitsuru, Character Design & Animation Direction by Maniwa Hideaki (真庭 秀明), Art Direction by Watanabe Yoshito (渡辺佳人), Direction by Uda Konosuke (宇田鋼之介).

Kindaichi after 7 years.

Looking back, when "***The File of Young Kindaichi***" began, it was still analogue production with cel + film. Then from Episode 45 "Black Death Butterfly Murder Case" File 2, it suddenly switched to digital production. From then on, we got through by gradually correcting basic colour direction data for each episode. So for me, *Kindaichi* was precious training in digital colouring and digital colour design. New works of such a *Kindaichi*. I couldn't help getting excited (laughs).

The producer's request to me was "Don't significantly change main character impressions from the previous *Kindaichi*." *Kindaichi* has been broadcast for a long time and reruns continue on various stations. The established image must be inherited as-is.

During the previous TV series production, Araki Shingo (荒木伸吾) & Himeno Michi (姫野美智) and Kubo Hidemi (窪秀巳) handled character design throughout, but this time each animation director would handle character design.

Different directors and animation directors for each is normal, but it's rare for continuously broadcast series to have different character designers. Moreover, they'd broadcast consecutively over 2 weeks, so we had to avoid significantly different impressions between those two works.

So I considered various things when doing colour design for both works.

First, when I coloured both Hajimes using *Kindaichi* colour direction from the end of the old series, they predictably became something different. Well, naturally. Hair highlight placement, eye drawing methods, facial contour volume - since animation differed from

the old series, the atmosphere naturally changed too. So various fine adjustments. Reconstructing balance matching each character designer's animation.

Hair highlight brightness against base hair colour tones, adding/subtracting colour tone intensity matching eye animation. Applied to each of the three - Hajime (はじめ), Miyuki (美雪), and Inspector Kenmochi (剣持). Naturally, we couldn't damage the "balance of three," so careful attention was needed. The result was this time's three characters. So "Opera House" and "Vampire Legend" have subtly different basic colour direction for all three characters.

Next, clothing colour tones.

For works with source material, we often base colours on those in the original, but static manga images and animation moving through space are quite different. Often they can't all be the same. Considering character overlap, presence, balance with art backgrounds, we think about colour combinations and presentation methods for the animation version.

For me, Miyuki has been "yellow + pink basics" since the old series (laughs), so both works were completed first with roughly the usual balance and volume. For Kenmochi in "Opera House," I wanted tension of "charging into a place with two previous murders," so I dressed him in a sharp dark suit. This matched the original book cover's dark suit too. In "Vampire Legend," I wanted relatively private casualness, so I used the unfashionable light brown jacket used often in the old series. V-neck sweaters are also typical Kenmochi (laughs).

Hajime always troubles me. He's supposedly the protagonist (laughs), so protagonist-like "presence" and "character standing" are necessary, but he's not a hero show protagonist and supposedly a normal high school student (bitter laugh), so the basics are subdued with one accent colour. So this time too, I considered him after somewhat settling other characters' colours.

Guest characters came up with costume designs close to the original, so I basically referenced the original to balance and place colours. "Opera House" owner Hibiki Shizuka (響静歌) and director Kageshima (影島) were done quite stereotypically. Lake Moon Leona's slightly orange hair colour was Director Ito-kun's preference (laughs). "Vampire Legend" had some characters with gender changed from the original, so those parts were original. Personally, I like Nekoma Junko (猫間純子) (laughs).

So, Hajime. Ultimately, "Opera House" settled on the original book cover's light green-based colour. "Vampire Legend," set entirely in the dim ruined hotel, I considered colours that would show well under the mystery-solving guest room's standing lamp, settling on a red parka with yellow shirt combination.

The old series often had multi-day stories with lots of character costume changes, especially Hajime - when stuck for clothing colour ideas, I'd directly use colours of shirts and jackets I often wore then (laughs), which was quite enjoyable. But this time both works were roughly one-night stories without costume changes - disappointing (laughs).

Now, main story design discussion.

Both works this time are the standard "incidents in buildings isolated from outside." Moreover, both are "rainy" "nights" (laughs). So almost all cuts were indoors.

Kindaichi's basics are dialogue drama, so I designed with scenes where characters gather and build conversations as brightness standards for main story. "Opera House" used the fireplace room, "Vampire Legend" used the lounge as colour direction standards. However, these aren't finishing colour direction "normals" but somewhat adjusted for brightness and colour tone matching background spaces. In my case, colour tones under natural light in bright places are basic "normal" colours, and when they enter various spaces, I adjust colour tones considering how they look and what impressions they give.

For example, putting so-called "normal" coloured characters directly against incandescent lighting room backgrounds makes them float white against the background and look unnatural. So this time too, I adjusted character colour direction brightness and shadow strength for each scene's space, then added that space's light colour tones. In the Opera House theatres darkness, I added background darkness blue for blending.

This time, especially for "Vampire Legend," I aimed for overall dimmer colours than "Opera House" to create the oppressive feeling of never leaving the hotel and the scary atmosphere of vampire legends.

I set mystery-solving scenes relatively brightly too. After all, it's "mystery solving" - revealing and explaining trick secrets. So I considered making things easily visible. However, "Vampire Legend" followed the story and was kept slightly darker. But it created good atmosphere with tightly focused highlights.

Like this, both works are finished as almost entirely "colour-changed" works (laughs). Looking back, places using "normal" colour direction were just the final few cuts in both "Opera House" and "Vampire Legend."

Adding to scene colour design designed this way, I apply arrangements cut by cut following directorial flow - intentionally exaggerating for impression or conversely burying to erase impression. First create atmosphere, then add meaning. Especially important for works like *Kindaichi*, and very enjoyable work for colour designers and colour directors. Incidentally, this time Akimoto Yuki (秋元由紀) handled "Opera House" colour direction, while I handled "Vampire Legend" colour direction myself.

Additionally, both works this time had Ota Sunao-kun's (太田直) Toei Animation special effects team working hard. Character eye gradations and gradient brush shadows added to character shadows are mostly the special effects team's handwork. While Toei works normally can't add elaborate special effects to TV productions, they worked hard as if releasing daily frustrations (laughs).

Such slightly luxurious effort went into "*The File of Young Kindaichi SP*" (laughs).

The other day, talking with Directors Ito-kun and Uda-kun, we laughed that Inspector Kenmochi is probably about our actual age now. Ito-kun, Uda-kun, and I are roughly the same age. So we thought, "Ah, we're 'old men' too now" (laughs). Though we're such "old men," we'd like to do "*The File of Young Kindaichi*" again.

(07.11.13)